A few facts you really should know about the Synoptic Gospels
(*Various Sources*)

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i. The Synoptic Gospels – Matthew, Mark and Luke – were so designated by J.J. Griesbach (1776) because they "see together" (hence "synoptic") the life of Christ, and, as such, they may be laid side-by-side to compare the parallel accounts.

ii. The historicity of the Gospels has been under siege for many centuries. The fact that they continue to withstand scrutiny and inspire confidence in their readers supports the trustworthiness of these writings. Arguments for the historicity or historical trustworthiness of the Gospels are based on a number of grounds:

- Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John were all in good positions to remember or learn about the life of Jesus. They all wrote their Gospels within the first century, a comparatively short period of time after the events they narrated.
- The Gospel genre most closely resembles that of other relatively trustworthy ancient biographies and histories.
- It is probable that the four Evangelists would have wanted to record accurate history and that Christian tradition carefully preserved information about Jesus.
- Historical details abound in the Gospels, giving the impression that history is being recorded, albeit a theological history. The apparent contradictions among the documents can be plausibly harmonized.
- The so-called hard sayings of Jesus, along with the topics the Gospels never address (e.g. circumcision), further support the historicity of these texts.
- Non-Christian writers, the evidence of archaeology, and later Christian writers all provide further support.
- Particularly telling are those references to the Jesus tradition in the NT epistles that predate the composition of the Gospels. These references demonstrate that accurate information about Jesus was circulating by word of mouth long before the first written accounts of his life were penned (cf. Phil.2:5-11).

iii. Each Synoptic Gospel has a number of distinctives or characteristics.

- **Matthew's Gospel:**
  - Jewish and OT background (cf. OT 'fulfillment' motif)
  - Jesus as King (Mat. 1:1-17: Genealogy)
  - Jesus' teaching (5 Discourses: Matt.5-7; 10; 13; 18, 23-24).
  - Universalist features ('Great Commission': make disciples of all nations)
  - Interest in the Church (cf. Mat.16:18; 18: 15-17)
  - Call to do God's will (cf. Mat.7:21, 24, 26)
  - Great eschatological interest (cf. Mat. 24-25)
  - A Comprehensive Gospel (from Jesus' birth to Church's commissioning)
- **Mark's Gospel:**
  - A simple, succinct, unadorned, yet vivid account of Jesus' ministry.
  - An emphasis more on what Jesus did than said
  - Jesus' divinity & humanity reflected (cf. Mk.4:38; 11:12)
  - Jesus as teacher (cf. Mk.4:1f.; 6:2)
  - Jesus as a suffering servant (cf. Mk.8:31ff.)
  - Jesus' Passion emphasised (Mk. 11-15)
  - The Messianic secret (cf. Mk.1: 34, 44; 3:12; 9:9)
  - Aramaic words often used in reporting what Jesus said (cf. Mk. 5:41)
  - Disciples and discipleship (cf. Mk.8:34ff.)
  - Imminent eschatology (cf. Mk.13)

- **Luke's Gospel:**
  - More accounts of Jesus' deeds and parables than the other Gospels
  - Repeated use of the Messianic title "Son of Man" (cf. Lk.19:10)
  - Jesus as prophet (cf. Lk.4:14-30)
  - Universalist features (cf. Lk.3: Genealogy; Acts of the Apostles)
  - The Holy Spirit (cf. Lk.4:1, 14)
  - Prayer (cf. Lk.3: 21; 6:12)
  - Special consideration for the socially underprivileged (cf. Lk.12:33)
  - Stewardship of material possessions (cf. Lk.16)
  - Joy (cf. Lk.1:14; 2:10; 10:17)

iv. While each Synoptic Gospel has a number of distinctives, they also all share a basic theological perspective:

- The dawning of the Kingdom of God.
- Fulfillment of the promises of Scripture.
- Future eschatology.
- The centrality of the Passion of Jesus.
- The importance of faith.

v. Each of the Synoptic Gospels follows the same basic structure with regard to its portrayal of Jesus ministry. Beginning with the ministry of John the Baptist, the focus shifts to Jesus' ministry – his baptism, temptation, miracles of healing, casting out demons, good deeds, and teaching – his rejection, suffering and death, and concludes with the account of his resurrection. Only Matthew and Luke include the account of Jesus' birth.

vi. The earthly ministry of Jesus lasted about three years. It is usually divided up as follows:

- The Year of Inauguration
- The Year of Popularity (Early-Galilean/Middle-Galilean/Later-Galilean phases)
- The Year of Opposition
- The Final Months
- The Final Week

vii. Although students of the Gospels should have a good working knowledge of the contents of the Synoptic Gospels, the following components of the narrative are particularly noteworthy in Matthew's Gospel:

- The Genealogy of Jesus Christ (1:1-17)
- The Birth of Jesus Christ (1:18-25)
- The Sermon on the Mount (5:1-7:27)
- Parables of the Kingdom – Sower/ Weeds/ Mustard Seed/ Leaven/ Hidden Treasure/ Pearl of Great Price/ Net/ New and Old Treasures (13:1-52)
- Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (14:13-21)
- Peter Confesses Jesus as the Christ at Caesarea Philippi (16:13-20)
- Jesus Foretells His Death and Resurrection (16:21-23)
- The Transfiguration (17:1-13)
- The Triumphal Entry (21:1-11)
- Denunciation of the Scribes and Pharisees and the Olivet (23:1-25:46)
- Peter Denies Jesus (26:69-75)
- The Crucifixion and Death of Jesus (27:32-56)
- The Resurrection (28:1-10)
- The Great Commission (28:16-20)

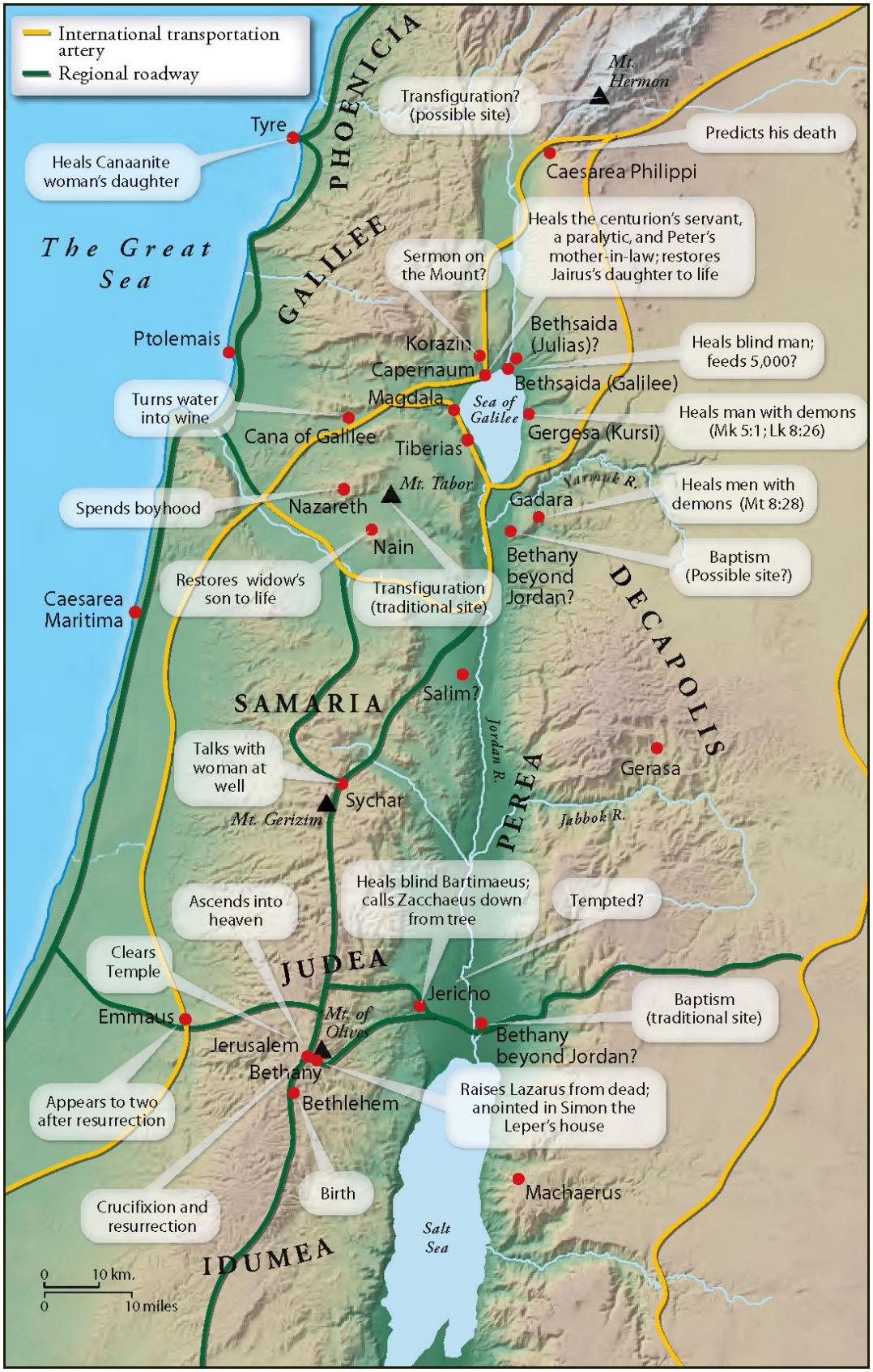
viii. Students should be able to identify the location of the following accounts in Mark's Gospel:

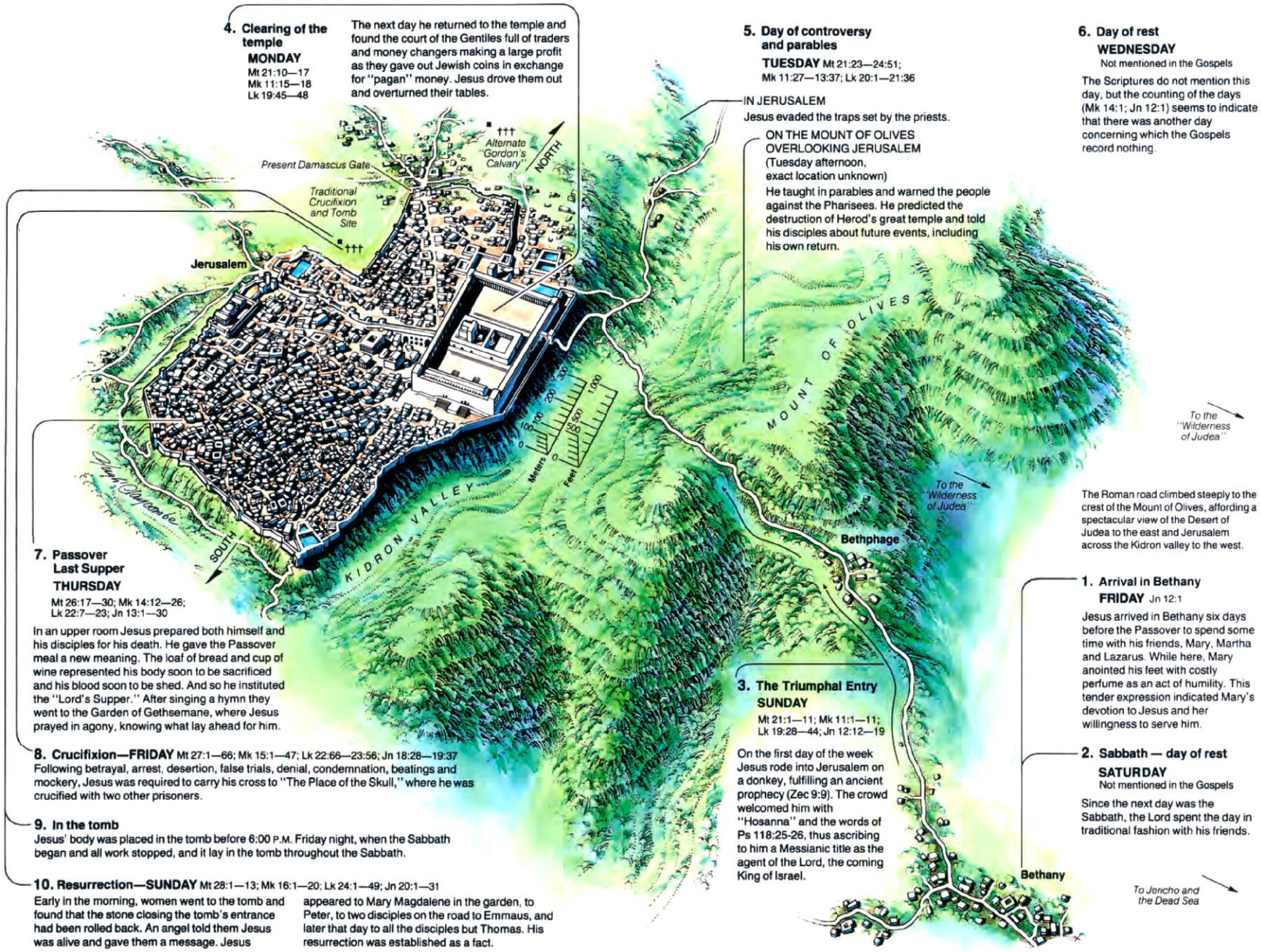
- John the Baptist Prepares the Way (1:1-8)
- Parables of the Kingdom – Sower/ Lamp on a Stand/ Growing Seed/ Mustard Seed (4:1-34)
- Jesus Heals a Woman and Jairus's Daughter (5:21-43)
- Jesus Feeds the Five Thousand (6:30-44)
- Jesus Walks on the Water (6:45-52)
- Jesus Feeds the Four Thousand (8:1-10)
- Jesus Heals a Blind Man at Bethsaida in Two Stages (8:22-26)
- Peter Confesses Jesus As the Christ at Caesarea Philippi (8:27-30)
- The Transfiguration (9:2-13)
- Jesus Heals Blind Bartimaeus (10:46-52)
- Jesus Cleanses the Temple (11:15-19)
- Paying Taxes to Caesar (12:13-17)
- The Greatest Commandment – Love the Lord Your God (12:28-34)
- Jesus Foretells the Temple's Destruction & Signs of the End of the Age (13:1-37)
- The Crucifixion (15:21-41)

ix. Students should be able to identify the location of the following accounts in Luke's Gospel:

- Birth of John the Baptist Foretold (1:5-25)
- Birth of Jesus Foretold (1:26-38)
- The Angel's Announcement to the Shepherds (2:8-21)
- Jesus Presented at the Temple/ Encounters Simeon and Anna (2:22-38)
- The Boy Jesus in the Temple at the Age of Twelve (2:41-52)
- The Genealogy of Jesus Christ (3:23-38)
- Jesus Rejected at Nazareth (4:16-30)
- The Sermon on the Plain (6:17-49)
- Jesus Raises a Widow's Son (7:11-17)
- Peter Confesses Jesus As the Christ at Caesarea Philippi (9:18-20)
- The Transfiguration (9:28-36)
- Jesus Sends Out the Seventy-Two (10:1-20)
- Parable of the Good Samaritan (10:25-37)
- Jesus at the Home of Martha and Mary (10:38-42)
- The Lord's Prayer (11:1-13)
- The Parable of the Rich Fool (12:13-21)
- Parables of the Lost Sheep/ Lost Coin/ Lost Son (15:1-32)
- The Rich Man and Lazarus (16:19-31)
- Jesus Cleanses Ten Lepers (17:11-19)
- The Coming of the Kingdom of God (17:20-37)
- Parable of the Pharisee and the Tax Collector (18:9-14)
- Jesus Encounters the Chief Tax Collector, Zacchaeus (19:1-10)
- Jesus Weeps over Jerusalem (19:41-44)
- Jesus Foretells the Temple's Destruction & Signs of the End of the Age (21:5-38)
- The Crucifixion (23:26-49)
- The Resurrection (24:1-12)
- Jesus Meets Two Disciples on the Road to Emmaus (24:13-35)
- Jesus Appears to His Disciples (24:36-49)
- The Ascension (24:50-53)

x. Students should be able to identify the following locations & events on a map:





4. Clearing of the temple
MONDAY
Mt 21:10—17
Mk 11:15—18
Lk 19:45—48

The next day he returned to the temple and found the court of the Gentiles full of traders and money changers making a large profit as they gave out Jewish coins in exchange for "pagan" money. Jesus drove them out and overturned their tables.

5. Day of controversy and parables
TUESDAY Mt 21:23—24:51; Mk 11:27—13:37; Lk 20:1—21:36

IN JERUSALEM
Jesus evaded the traps set by the priests.

ON THE MOUNT OF OLIVES OVERLOOKING JERUSALEM (Tuesday afternoon, exact location unknown)
He taught in parables and warned the people against the Pharisees. He predicted the destruction of Herod's great temple and told his disciples about future events, including his own return.

6. Day of rest
WEDNESDAY
Not mentioned in the Gospels

The Scriptures do not mention this day, but the counting of the days (Mk 14:1; Jn 12:1) seems to indicate that there was another day concerning which the Gospels record nothing.

The Roman road climbed steeply to the crest of the Mount of Olives, affording a spectacular view of the Desert of Judea to the east and Jerusalem across the Kidron valley to the west.

1. Arrival in Bethany
FRIDAY Jn 12:1

Jesus arrived in Bethany six days before the Passover to spend some time with his friends, Mary, Martha and Lazarus. While here, Mary anointed his feet with costly perfume as an act of humility. This tender expression indicated Mary's devotion to Jesus and her willingness to serve him.

2. Sabbath — day of rest
SATURDAY
Not mentioned in the Gospels

Since the next day was the Sabbath, the Lord spent the day in traditional fashion with his friends.

3. The Triumphal Entry
SUNDAY
Mt 21:1—11; Mk 11:1—11; Lk 19:28—44; Jn 12:12—19

On the first day of the week Jesus rode into Jerusalem on a donkey, fulfilling an ancient prophecy (Zec 9:9). The crowd welcomed him with "Hosanna" and the words of Ps 118:25-26, thus ascribing to him a Messianic title as the agent of the Lord, the coming King of Israel.

7. Passover Last Supper
THURSDAY
Mt 26:17—30; Mk 14:12—26; Lk 22:7—23; Jn 13:1—30

In an upper room Jesus prepared both himself and his disciples for his death. He gave the Passover meal a new meaning. The loaf of bread and cup of wine represented his body soon to be sacrificed and his blood soon to be shed. And so he instituted the "Lord's Supper." After singing a hymn they went to the Garden of Gethsemane, where Jesus prayed in agony, knowing what lay ahead for him.

8. Crucifixion—FRIDAY Mt 27:1—66; Mk 15:1—47; Lk 22:66—23:56; Jn 18:28—19:37
Following betrayal, arrest, desertion, false trials, denial, condemnation, beatings and mockery, Jesus was required to carry his cross to "The Place of the Skull," where he was crucified with two other prisoners.

9. In the tomb
Jesus' body was placed in the tomb before 6:00 P.M. Friday night, when the Sabbath began and all work stopped, and it lay in the tomb throughout the Sabbath.

10. Resurrection—SUNDAY Mt 28:1—13; Mk 16:1—20; Lk 24:1—49; Jn 20:1—31
Early in the morning, women went to the tomb and found that the stone closing the tomb's entrance had been rolled back. An angel told them Jesus was alive and gave them a message. Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene in the garden, to Peter, to two disciples on the road to Emmaus, and later that day to all the disciples but Thomas. His resurrection was established as a fact.